The world in brief

Catch up quickly on the global stories that matter

Photograph: The Asahi Shimbun via Getty Imag

Takaichi Sanae won a landslide victory in **Japan's snap election**. The leader of the Liberal Democratic Party, who became prime minister a few months ago, is thought to have secured a two-thirds "supermajority" of seats in the lower house. Meanwhile, in a much tighter contest in Thailand, Anutin Charnvirakul, the prime minister, claimed victory for his conservative Bhumjaithai Party over the reformist opposition.

Morgan McSweeney resigned as **Sir Keir Starmer's** chief of staff. He had encouraged the prime minister to appoint Peter Mandelson as Britain's ambassador to America despite Lord Mandelson's links to Jeffrey Epstein. Mr McSweeney was an architect of Labour's resounding electoral victory in 2024. His resignation is unlikely to quell speculation that another Labour politician will challenge Sir Keir's leadership.

Israel's cabinet approved measures to make it easier for Jewish settlers to buy and register land in the **West Bank**. The country's hawkish defence and finance ministers, Israel Katz and Bezalel Smotrich, said that repealing Jordanian laws that ban land sales to Jews would remove "decades-old barriers" to development in the territory. Palestine's presidency said the new measures amount to

“annexation and displacement”. It called them “illegal, null and void”.

Narges Mohammadi was sentenced to more than seven additional years in jail by an Iranian court. The Iranian human-rights advocate, who won the Nobel peace prize in 2023, was accused of “gathering and collusion to commit crimes” and “propaganda activities”, according to her lawyer. Ms Mohammadi has reportedly been on a hunger strike for almost one week.

Juan Pablo Guanipa, a Venezuelan opposition figure who is close to María Corina Machado, an exiled Nobel prizewinner, was released from jail. Venezuela’s new government has promised to free “all political prisoners” jailed by Nicolás Maduro, a dictator whom America removed from power in January. Mr Guanipa, the former vice-president of the National Assembly, was detained in May 2025.

French prosecutors have encountered an obstacle in the **trial of identical twins** for murder: forensic experts cannot figure out from DNA evidence which of them fired the rifle, according to local media. The 33-year-old brothers are among five people accused of murdering two people in 2020 and attempting to kill several more.

Lindsey Vonn crashed in her highly anticipated comeback in the women’s downhill race at the Winter Olympics in Cortina d’Ampezzo. The American skier lost control after catching a gate 13 seconds into the race, breaking her left leg. She had surgery at an Italian hospital. Nine days earlier she had ruptured a ligament in her left knee. The 41-year-old had retired in 2019 after winning three Olympic gold medals. Breezy Johnson, another American, won today’s race.

Word of the week: *Comandos Jungla* (Jungle Commandos), an elite unit of Colombia’s anti-narcotics police. Read the full story.

Photograph: EPA

Japan goes to the polls

On Sunday Japan held a snap general election. Takaichi Sanae, the country's first female prime minister, called it last month, three months into her job. She hopes her high approval ratings will deliver a landslide. Exit polls suggest her Liberal Democratic Party and its coalition partner is set to win more than 300 out of the 465 in the lower house.

Ms Takaichi is not without her vulnerabilities. She was recently criticised for talking up the benefits of a cheap yen at the same time as the currency's historic weakness is squeezing household budgets. Indeed, Ms Takaichi's triumph will owe much to the weakness of her opponents. Ahead of the election, the main centre-left opposition formed a coalition, the Centrist Reform Alliance. It is flailing; polls suggest its constituent parties may lose half their seats. Voters who spurn the LDP are scattering to new parties of the far left and the far right. Japan is entering an era of multi-party politics, but one party, Japan's postwar behemoth, still looms above them all.

Photograph: EPA/Shutterstock

Thailand goes to the polls, too

Thai voters cast their ballots on Sunday to elect a new lower house of parliament. The general election is a three-way race between liberals, populists and conservatives. Move Forward, a liberal party, won the previous election in 2023, but the military-appointed senate blocked it from forming a government. Move Forward and its leaders were later banned from politics. A court found that their proposed reforms to Thailand's strict *lèse-majesté* laws, which forbid insulting the monarchy, breached the constitution. Most of Move Forward's members have regrouped into the new People's Party, which has been leading in the polls.

But the People's Party will probably fall short of a majority. That would give the upper hand to Anutin Charnvirakul, the prime minister and leader of the Thai Pride Party. A dealmaker, he will find it easier to put together a majority from the conservative and populist camps.

Photograph: Getty Images

A visit by Israel’s president tests Australia

Isaac Herzog, Israel’s president, will arrive in Australia on Sunday. He will visit Bondi Beach, the site of a devastating antisemitic attack in December. Many Australian Jews criticised the prime minister, Anthony Albanese, for failing to prevent the attack. The Israeli government linked the violence to Australia’s decision to recognise a Palestinian state. Mr Albanese will attempt to use Mr Herzog’s visit to regain the trust of the Jewish community.

But Mr Herzog’s arrival will test Australia’s fraying social cohesion. Some on the left have raised concerns about the visit, citing the Israeli government’s war in Gaza. On the right, a populist party, growing in popularity, is generally supportive. Authorities will try to keep a lid on any disquiet. New laws introduced after the Bondi attack enable the authorities to disband groups committing hate crimes and to ban protests. They are already being put to use. The New South Wales government has banned demonstrations in parts of Sydney during Mr Herzog’s stay, although protesters say they will defy the order.

Photograph: Reuters

Bunny boilers at the Super Bowl

The Seattle Seahawks and New England Patriots face off in the Super Bowl on Sunday. While the game itself offers several compelling storylines, much of the attention in the build-up has focused on the half-time performer, Bad Bunny. Born Benito Antonio Martínez Ocasio, he is one of the most streamed artists in the world and the king of Latin trap. Earlier this month he won three Grammy Awards, including album of the year. He has also infuriated supporters of President Donald Trump.

Conservatives object to his Spanish-language performances, his celebration of Latino culture and his criticism of the administration's anti-immigration policies. Mr Trump condemned his pick as half-time performer when it was announced, and Mr Bunny's remarks criticising Immigration and Customs Enforcement at the Grammys prompted a fresh backlash. One conservative group has advertised a rival "All-American" half-time broadcast featuring Kid Rock, a pro-Trump musician. Mr Bunny, for his part, was born in Puerto Rico—which is part of the United States.

Illustration: Sandra Navarro

The winners of this week’s quiz

Thank you to everyone who took part in this week’s quiz. The winners, chosen at random, were:

Linda Bonger, Zurich, Switzerland

Michel Simard, Gatineau, Canada

Kariem Abdellatif, Uebersyren, Luxembourg

They all gave the correct answers of: Yemen, Nigeria, Iran, Somalia and Syria. The theme is that they are all countries in which the second Trump administration has launched military action.

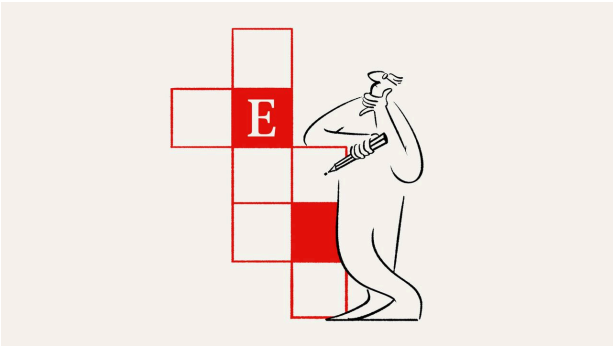

Illustration: The Economist

Mini crossword

We publish a new interactive edition of our crossword daily, allowing you to enter and check the answers and see explanations. Try it here.

Cryptic clues

1 across - Quiet before the French get into central position (5)

2 across - Test the leading currency (5)

3 across - Serif letter contains comb (5)

1 down - Mixed in portion to get red (5,4)

Straight clues

1 across - Flower; factory (5)

2 across - Tribunal or assessment (5)

3 across - To rummage; a type of gun (5)

1 down - A light-to-medium-bodied red wine (5,4)

There are two sets of clues, one for seasoned cruciverbalists and

the other for less experienced solvers. Both give the same answers.

Email all four answers, along with your home city and country, by 9am GMT on Monday to . We will pick three winners at random and crown them in Tuesday's edition.

If honour were profitable, everybody would be honourable.

Sir Thomas More